to visit Mahendragiri to see the progress of the upcoming integrated test complex.

I was happy to receive Dhawan at Mahendragiri and take him around. And soon we came to the test stand site where the marking pegs were in place. It did not strike me that I was showing to Dhawan something which I had altered not just without his permission, but also despite him telling me not to do it. It was another matter that I was confident of bringing him around sooner than later. Anyway, it was unlikely that Dhawan would remember the dimensions we discussed and, even if he did, he would be able to make out from the peg markings if it was 4m x 4m or 5m x 5m.

I was wrong. Just when he had turned to leave after inspecting the site when Dhawan paused for a moment, as if in hesitation, and asked John, 'What's the dimension of the test stand?

'5m x 5m,' replied John.

Now Dhawan turned to me.

'Nambi, I thought we had decided on 4m x 4m.'

I tried to explain things, but Dhawan cut me short.

'Who is the ISRO chairman?' Dhawan was rarely so curt.

'You, sir,' I replied.

'Then do as I tell you.'

There was no more discussion. The stand was built with a 4m x 4m basement, for single engine test, and this continues to be the facility to date.

Years later, after Dhawan had retired and when U R Rao was the ISRO chairman, I happened to be in a meeting where Dhawan was also present. It has been the custom at ISRO to have its former chairmen and some retired scientists in planning meetings. This one was to discuss configurations of the then proposed GSLV, and when the topic of ground testing came up, someone spoke about a cluster of engines, and the fact that we did not have a facility to test such a cluster.

Colonel Pant, a retired director of Sriharikota Range (SHAR), was quick to raise the question why a multiple-engine stand was not planned when Mahendragiri was being set up. It showed the shortsightedness of the team, he said. Several others echoed the argument blaming the LPSC team